

M-ZRT (ELI5)

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The purpose is not to calm the mind, but to remove what blocks intensity. It is not flow, nor is it relaxation.

The system evaluates automatically

Move your shoulders for a few seconds, then observe what happens. Very quickly, an evaluation “catch-it up”. It often arises even before the action itself, in the form of **anticipation**.

Now repeat exactly the same movement, but while facing a first-person shooter (FPS) video game with the HUD turned off, for example, Unreal Tournament 1999. In this case, evaluation does not activate immediately. Instead, it appears to be delayed, often by around 4 to 5 seconds.

Without a game:

Anticipation: ~5 seconds

Shoulder movement: ~3 seconds (you control it)

+1 second: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation (“Am I doing this right?”, “What’s the point?”)

This process reflects a **monitoring system** that activates in a nearly inevitable way.

With an FPS game, HUD off:

Anticipation: ~2 seconds (reduced)

Shoulder movement: ~3 seconds (you control it)

+5 seconds: emergence of meaning-search and evaluation (delayed)

What we observe here is a temporal shift. Evaluation is not removed, but delayed, because the monitoring load (Z) decreases a bit. This delay creates a window during which the action can exist without being immediately captured by the monitoring system.

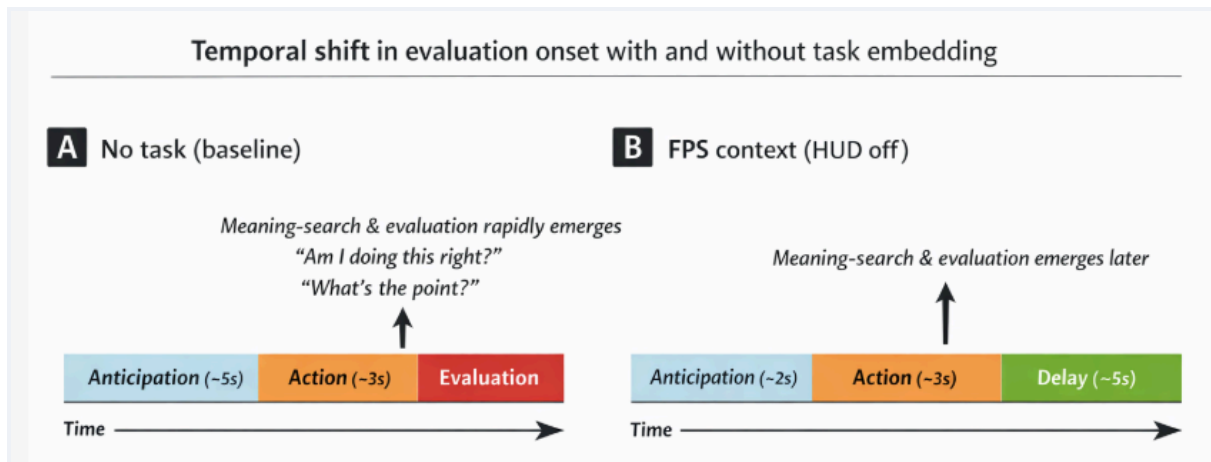


Figure 1: Task context creates a brief window where action escapes immediate monitoring.

In other words, it becomes possible to decrease Z simply by engaging with a first-person shooter (FPS) game. The aim is to lower it sufficiently to create a stable window. When this reduction is strong enough, the reappearance of much more intense dopaminergic responses can be observed.

The monitoring system does not only evaluate actions. It also monitors attempts to bypass it. It therefore includes the broader “setup” themselves, such as choosing a game. This is why the first hours of a game are often experienced as “magical,” and then the effect fades. The system learns the context, anticipates what will happen, and reintegrates the experience into an evaluative loop.

As soon as there is anticipation or comparison, the monitoring system reactivates and captures the event. After repeated attempts, the system may remain active and vigilant for some time, making subsequent attempts less effective.

Rules:

The duration of most exercises must remain seconds-short

The exercise should not be repeated multiple times within the same day

It should be left without analysis

It should be treated as a one-off event, then abandoned

It operates as a **switch-like** logic, and should not become something to improve. It is not a skill to master.

The exercise may be repeated, but only if it is not anticipated. Each occurrence should be initiated as late as possible, with minimal prior thought, and without analysis afterward. In any case, each instance should not last more than a few seconds.

Familiarity Closes the Window

Suppose I give you a task to perform. The first time anticipation is relatively low, because the action is not yet well known.

But afterward, you know what to expect. Anticipation increases. The monitor recognizes the situation, reactivates, and **captures** the action. At that point, the task loses its effect, because it is immediately evaluated.

If you wait longer, for example a day, part of that familiarity fades. The memory is less precise, the context becomes partially “open” again.

Under these conditions, the monitor is less active, or slower to trigger. The task can pass again.

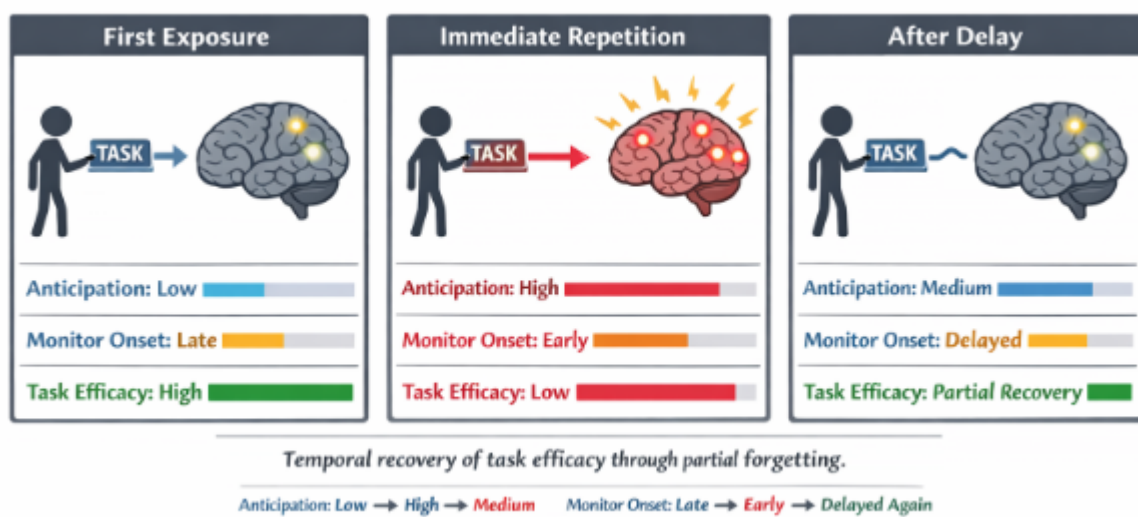


Figure 2. After a delay, partial decay of the representation in memory reduces anticipation, slowing monitor onset and reopening a brief window in which the task can again operate. However, this does not mean the task works better on the first attempt, as multiple attempts may be required.

Extended preparation tends to sustain anticipatory loops, whereby repeated simulations of future action increase cumulative evaluative load and reinforce monitoring. This prolonged pre-action phase also generates cognitive debt, as partially specified intentions remain active and occupy background resources. In contrast, **acting at the last moment** compresses the interval between intention and execution, thereby limiting the duration of anticipatory processing and reducing opportunities for iterative evaluation. Repetition is allowed, **but only if the participant does not think about the exercise in advance**. Each instance must be triggered at the last possible moment, without planning, and then abandoned without analysis.

There are two goals: reduce Z while maintaining, or even increasing, salience.

Salience is the degree to which something stands out in experience, captures attention, feels vivid, important, or mentally foregrounded. Children naturally live in a high-salience regime without trying. In adults, the same signals still exist, but they are quickly evaluated, categorized, or dismissed, which cuts the process short. So salience is not lost, it is just blocked at entry by evaluation.

The main Z-reduction task:

Download Unreal Tournament (1999), **don't remove, but ignore the HUD**, and start a match with no performance goal. Level of AI/bots: easy to mild.

While playing, make a brief shoulder movement, only once, without prolonging it, then take a very small sip of coffee. Then close the game. Switch to a self-selected music-video.

On subsequent days, occasionally vary the coffee sequence, for example by taking it before the game or the micro-movement. The goal is to keep the pattern from becoming recognizable. In the same spirit, you can also skip a day at random to maintain unpredictability.

Right after the micro-movement, you can add what I call a micro-task. It's a task that lasts only until the end of the round, the goal is to not wake-up the monitor, so the micro-movement is not immediately captured by it. Example: this round, aim at the opponent's torso.

So it becomes: micro-movement → aim at the torso → when the round ends, drop the task completely.

As seen before, an exercise or a session can lower Z (evaluative load) only while it is being done, the moment it becomes something **to think about**, it turns back into evaluation and increases Z. The whole session doesn't last more than 30 seconds.

Sometimes, nothing more is needed. What follows are optional directions intended to improve the likelihood of a shift.

Summary: Tips to lower Z

Looking into a box

Minimizing narrative in daily life

Externalizing Time Regulation

Minimal Verbal Cues

Kefir

Theanine

Low-Instrumentality Media

Very low-dose alcohol

Attenuation of Evaluative Load Through Bounded, Non-Instrumental Visual Engagement

Brief engagement with a bounded, low-information visual field, such as looking into a box, can plausibly reduce Z by attenuating evaluative load and disrupting goal-directed processing. The perceptual enclosure limits exposure to socially and temporally structured cues, thereby decreasing contextual evaluation pressure. At the same time, the absence of an explicit task or outcome requirement maintains the activity in a non-instrumental regime, preventing immediate recruitment of monitoring systems. The stimulus itself provides minimal but sufficient salience to sustain attention without triggering optimization or performance tracking. This combination, constrained input, low goal specification, and weak predictive structure, creates a transient window in which evaluative processes are less likely to engage, thereby lowering Z. Crucially, this effect depends on the absence of anticipatory framing or outcome-oriented intent, as the introduction of such elements rapidly reinstates evaluative dynamics and negates the reduction.

Minimizing Evaluative Load in Everyday Interaction: A Low-Z Response Framework

In everyday social interactions, common prompts such as greetings, small talk, or requests for self-description systematically induce evaluative load by inviting individuals to produce narratives, justify actions, or stabilize an identity. Within the Z framework, these micro-demands elevate contextual load by activating monitoring processes, even when the stakes are objectively low. A low-Z response strategy therefore consists in minimizing narrative expansion, avoiding identity-based formulations, and redirecting interaction toward immediate procedural or functional elements. Empirically, this is achieved through short, closed responses, absence of justification, and rapid transitions to task-relevant content. Such responses prevent the escalation of self-referential processing and reduce the likelihood that the individual becomes an object of evaluation. Importantly, the effectiveness of this approach does not rely on suppressing social norms, but on satisfying them at a minimal threshold while preserving a non-instrumental, low-monitoring state.

Externalizing Time Regulation Reduces Continuous Monitoring and Lowers Z

Replacing active time-checking with externally scheduled auditory cues reduces Z by interrupting a primary channel of continuous self-monitoring. Clock checking repeatedly triggers rapid evaluative cycles, involving temporal comparison, task projection, and implicit performance assessment, thereby maintaining both contextual load (Z_ctx) and reinforcing structural monitoring tendencies (Z_shift). In contrast, alarms externalize temporal regulation, converting a self-initiated, high-frequency monitoring loop into a sparse, externally driven signal. This shift reduces the need for anticipatory control, limits micro-evaluations, and decreases fragmentation of cognitive activity. As a result, the system operates with fewer evaluative intrusions, allowing longer intervals of non-instrumental processing and thereby lowering overall Z.

Minimal Verbal Cues as Low-Z Modulators in Non-Instrumental Play (UT99 Context)

In non-instrumental gameplay contexts such as short UT99 sessions, brief and low-semantic verbal cues may function as micro-interventions that reduce evaluative load (Z) without introducing new goal structures. These phrases are characterized by minimal informational content, absence of optimization signals, and low temporal extension, thereby avoiding recruitment of monitoring processes. Rather than directing behavior, they act as permissive markers that stabilize a transient, non-instrumental regime by preventing escalation into performance tracking, comparison, or outcome anticipation. Importantly, their efficacy does not derive from repetition or deliberate use as a strategy, but from their capacity to remain cognitively lightweight and non-binding. When they become objectified, rehearsed, or anticipated, they risk reintroducing evaluative structure and thus increasing Z. As such, low-Z verbal cues should be understood not as techniques to be applied, but as ephemeral linguistic residues compatible with brief windows of reduced monitoring, allowing spontaneous action to persist without immediate capture by evaluative systems.

List of possible sentences:

“not trying to win” “no need to improve” “doesn’t matter” “this is enough” “no pressure” “no score needed” “nothing to do” “no goal” “let it happen” “follow nothing” “no direction” “random is fine” “just moving” “stop checking” “back to nothing” “no change” “leave it like this”

Kefir as a Non-Instrumental Modulator of Permissive Affective Regimes Through Low-Salience Gut–Brain Signaling

Kefir consumption can be interpreted as a low-level modulator of the conditions that permit access to a permissive affective regime such as Ease, rather than as a direct inducer of positive affect. As a fermented matrix containing diverse microbial strains, kefir interacts with the gut–brain axis through vagal signaling, metabolic byproducts, and mild immunomodulatory effects, collectively reducing baseline physiological tension without producing a salient or easily attributable subjective shift. This low detectability is critical, as it avoids triggering evaluative monitoring processes that would otherwise block regime transition. In parallel, kefir presents slight but continuous sensory variability, including acidity, carbonation, and texture fluctuations, introducing weak, non-structured prediction errors that disrupt rigid perceptual expectations without forming an instrumental target. Its typical mode of intake, brief, non-ritualized, and non-goal-directed, further prevents the emergence of temporal extension and self-observation. Within the Z framework, kefir can therefore be understood as contributing to a reduction in accumulated and contextual load while preserving the absence of structural shift toward monitoring, thereby increasing the probability of spontaneous regime transition without itself constituting a method or controllable intervention.

L-Theanine as a Low-Salience Stabilizer of Permissive Affective Conditions

L-theanine can be conceptualized, within the same framework, as a low-salience modulator that stabilizes the background conditions required for access to a permissive affective regime such as Ease, without acting as a direct or attributable inducer. As an amino acid primarily found in tea, L-theanine crosses the blood–brain barrier and subtly influences cortical dynamics through modulation of glutamatergic transmission, mild GABAergic support, and promotion of alpha-band activity, collectively shifting neural tone toward a state of reduced internal friction while preserving wakeful clarity. Crucially, these effects tend to remain phenomenologically diffuse, lacking sharp onset or identifiable markers, which prevents recruitment of evaluative monitoring processes that would otherwise interfere with regime entry. Unlike more salient agents, L-theanine does not impose a distinct subjective signature that could be tracked, anticipated, or instrumentalized. Its integration into ordinary, low-ritual contexts, such as incidental tea consumption, further limits temporal structuring and self-referential observation. Within the Z framework, L-theanine thus contributes to a background attenuation of accumulated and contextual load while maintaining structural neutrality, increasing the likelihood of spontaneous regime transition without becoming an object of control or expectation.

Low-Instrumentality Media and the Reduction of Evaluative Load

Exposure to low-complexity, highly predictable legacy animated cartoons or naïve telefilms may reduce Z by limiting the activation of evaluative monitoring systems. These formats typically rely on repetitive narrative loops, exaggerated but stable character dynamics, and simplified moral structures, thereby constraining contextual load and delaying the onset of structural monitoring. Their visual and temporal construction often includes cyclical gags, elastic causality, and non-consequential outcomes, which further reduces the need for prediction accuracy or interpretative effort. The viewer is not required to track performance, extract layered meaning, or optimize understanding, allowing engagement to remain non-instrumental and weakly evaluated. However, this effect remains contingent on the absence of meta-cognitive framing: when the content is deliberately selected, analyzed, or instrumentalized as a regulatory tool, monitoring re-engages and Z increases. Thus, the Z-reducing property of such cartoons emerges not solely from their simplicity, but from their capacity to maintain a regime in which evaluative processes fail to stabilize.

Differential Effects of Benzodiazepines and Alcohol on Monitoring and Perceptual Salience

Benzodiazepines (e.g., diazepam, alprazolam) act primarily through potentiation of GABAergic inhibition, producing well-established effects including reduced anxiety, decreased vigilance, and dampened activity in threat-related circuitry.

However, this reduction is not selective. In addition to lowering evaluative monitoring (Z), benzodiazepines also reduce overall perceptual gain. Sensory input remains present but is experienced with diminished intensity and contrast. This produces a condition of lowered tension without enhanced experiential richness. In signal-processing terms, the effect resembles a low-pass filter applied uniformly across cognitive and perceptual systems.

Alcohol, particularly at very low doses, also reduces top-down control, notably within prefrontal systems associated with evaluation and self-monitoring. However, alcohol does not reduce perceptual salience to the same extent. Sensory input remains relatively vivid and, in some cases, may be experienced as more immersive or fluid due to reduced interference from control processes.

Within the proposed framework, entry into the Ease regime - the regime that sustain joy - requires two simultaneous conditions: reduction of monitoring (Z) and preservation of sufficient perceptual salience

Benzodiazepines satisfy the first condition but undermine the second. Very low dose alcohol, by contrast, satisfies both conditions more effectively by reducing monitoring while maintaining access to perceptually rich input.

The Z/Salience Ratio

These observations suggest that the critical variable is not Z in isolation, but the ratio between monitoring and perceptual salience.

We can formalize this as: low Z / low salience → attenuated, non-salient experience while low Z / high salience → permissive window for high-intensity positive states

Thus, interventions that reduce monitoring must be evaluated in terms of their impact on signal integrity. A reduction in monitoring that simultaneously degrades perceptual input will not produce the desired regime. So a very low dose reduces Z, while maintaining salience.

Annexe A: Saliency Exercises in-Game

Peripheral enemy

You see an enemy, don't treat it as a target, let a small detail (color, animation) become salient instead.

Ground texture

Briefly look at the ground while moving, let one texture detail take over, then move on.

Weapon as object

Ignore its function, notice a small visual detail (shape, sway) as if it were just a decorative object.

Amplified micro-movement

Make a tiny movement (small strafe or slight rotation) and let that movement become the main event.

Ignore the HUD

If HUD is on, mentally drop it, let a random visual element replace its importance.

Slight wrong trajectory

Take a slightly "incorrect" path and let an unexpected detail appear (angle, shadow, opening).

Enemy as background

For a brief moment, treat another player as part of the environment, not as a target.

Perceptual freeze

While moving, let one element feel "frozen" in your perception, even as everything else moves.

Background focus

Ignore the main action, let the background become more important than the gameplay.

Visual overlap

Notice when two elements overlap (player + wall, light + effect) and let that overlap become salient.

Expression mismatch

Look at a player or object and briefly treat its state as "wrong" (too fast, too still, slightly off), let that mismatch become salient.

Timing distortion

Let a small event (movement, sound) feel either too early or too late, without correcting it.

Background becomes event

Something minor in the background suddenly takes the role of the main event, like a bad edit in a clip.

Sound-image desync

Hear a sound and loosely associate it with the wrong visual element, let that mismatch sit for a second.

Object identity drift

Look at an object and let its “category” feel unstable (weapon, decoration, something else), without resolving it.

Micro-surprise without cause

Treat a completely normal event as if it were unexpected, let the surprise attach to something trivial.

Delayed recognition

See something obvious but let recognition lag artificially, so the detail exists before it’s “understood”.

Motion inconsistency

While moving, let one element feel like it follows a slightly different physics than the rest.

Useless emphasis

Something irrelevant (light flicker, shadow, texture) gets full emphasis, like an editor made a mistake.

False transition

Feel like the scene is about to change (as in a clip), but it doesn't, hold that suspended transition briefly.

Annexe B: Low-Instrumental Micro-Exercises

Low-instrumental micro-exercises are brief, non-goal-directed interventions designed to disrupt evaluative monitoring and prevent the stabilization of instrumental cognitive regimes. Rather than inducing positive affect directly, these exercises operate by transiently reducing evaluative load and destabilizing predictive and narrative continuity. This annexe proposes a functional taxonomy of such exercises based on their underlying mechanisms, including optimization disruption, non-resolution, passive extinction, attentional fragmentation, weak re-labeling, arbitrary prioritization, non-utilitarian precision, objectless affect induction, and micro-behavioral anomaly. Each category selectively interferes with distinct components of evaluative load, thereby increasing the probability of accessing permissive affective regimes without triggering monitoring.

Main Typology

Type	Core Mechanism	Example	Effect on Z
Optimization Disruption	Interrupts improvement and selection loops	Closing a video when it becomes enjoyable	↓ Z_ctx, prevents evaluative reinforcement
Non-Resolution (Suspension)	Maintains open cognitive tension without closure	Asking a question without answering	Blocks predictive completion, delays monitoring
Passive Extinction	Allows representations to fade without maintenance	Letting a mental image disappear	↓ Z_acc, reduces active control loops
Fragmentation / Discontinuity	Breaks temporal and narrative coherence	Jumping between random book pages	Destabilizes Z_shift, weakens narrative continuity
Weak Re-Labeling	Alters perceptual categorization without goal	Labeling something “almost interesting”	Shifts salience without triggering evaluation

Arbitrary Prioritization	Assigns importance without justification	Selecting one sound as central	Decouples attention from utility-driven hierarchy
Non-Utilitarian Precision	Engages precision without functional goal	Aligning an object perfectly for no reason	Separates accuracy from optimization processes
Objectless Affect Induction	Generates affect without external referent	Feeling recognition without a target	Breaks causal binding between stimulus and affect
Micro-Behavioral Anomaly	Introduces small unpredictable deviations	Stopping abruptly while walking	Disrupts motor predictability, weakens automatic scripts

Conceptual Summary

Across categories, these exercises share a common property: they introduce localized violations of instrumental coherence without escalating into explicit meta-cognitive control. Their effectiveness does not derive from their content, but from their capacity to prevent evaluation from stabilizing. Importantly, when these actions are reframed as techniques, repeated systematically, or evaluated for effectiveness, their functional properties collapse, as evaluative monitoring is reinstated.

The operational distinction is not between different exercises, but between two regimes:

- **Performing the exercise** → transient reduction of evaluative load
- **Thinking about the exercise** → immediate reinstatement of evaluation

Optimization Disruption

- Start a video, close it the moment it becomes enjoyable
- Pick a suboptimal YouTube video without correcting the choice

Non-Resolution (Suspension)

- Ask a question internally and do not answer it
- Think “what was I about to do?” and leave it unresolved
- Generate a vague expectation like “something is about to happen”
- Begin forming a sentence internally and abandon it mid-way

Passive Extinction

- Visualize a simple object and let it fade without refreshing it
- Notice a sound and let it disappear from attention naturally
- Hold a thought and allow it to dissolve without returning to it

Fragmentation / Discontinuity

- Open a book, read one paragraph, jump to another random page
- Walk, stop suddenly, then resume without explanation
- Watch a video while randomly skipping forward and backward
- Start an activity, interrupt it quickly, and switch to another

Weak Re-Labeling

- Look at something and think “almost interesting”

Arbitrary Prioritization (Salience)

- Pick one sound in the environment and treat it as central
- Focus on a background detail as if it were the main event
- Assign importance to something without looking directly at it
- Treat a minor visual element as the “core” of the scene

Non-Utilitarian Precision

- Place items symmetrically without needing the result

Objectless Affect Induction

- Generate a feeling of recognition without a person

9. Micro-Behavioral Anomaly

- Stop walking abruptly for no reason
- Change direction slightly while moving without cause
- Alter your rhythm briefly, then return to normal
- Perform a small unexpected gesture, then drop it

Condensed view

Each category targets a different failure mode of evaluation:

- Break optimization
- Prevent resolution
- Stop maintenance
- Disrupt continuity
- Shift labels
- Reassign importance
- Decouple precision
- Remove object–affect link
- Inject unpredictability